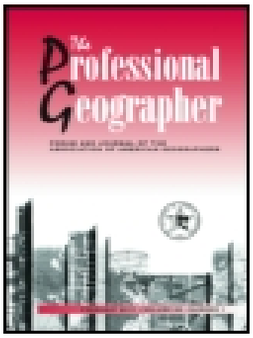

The Professional Geographer

ISSN: 0033-0124 (Print) 1467-9272 (Online) Journal homepage: http://www.tandfonline.com/loi/rtpg20

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**To cite this article:** Steven M. Radil, Raymond J. Dezzani & Lanny D. McAden (2016): Geographies of U.S. Police Militarization and the Role of the 1033 Program, The Professional Geographer, DOI: 10.1080/00330124.2016.1212666

**To link to this article:** http://dx.doi.org/10.1080/00330124.2016.1212666

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# Geographies of U.S. Police Militarization and the Role of the 1033 Program

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Concerns about police militarization have become an important public policy issue since the aggressive police response to the 2014 protests in Ferguson, Missouri, where police officers used military-style equipment to confront protestors. This event was a stark visual reminder that many U.S. police departments have used federal programs to acquire surplus military equipment, including weapons, armored vehicles, and body armor. We explore the geographies and histories of one the most important programs, called 1033, which supplies police with military equipment under the rationale of prosecuting the War on Drugs. We show that the legal blurring of the police and the military has been ongoing for decades at the national scale but this has resulted in an uneven landscape of police militarization at the county scale. We also investigate one of the most common global arguments for why police become militarized, which is the presence of Special Weapons and Tactics-style paramilitary teams, finding little support for that claim. More geographic inquiry is needed to understand the trajectories, causes, and consequences of police militarization. **Key Words: 1033, law enforcement, militarization, policing, SWAT.**

自从 2014 年密苏里弗格森的抗议事件中, 警察使用军事武器对抗抗议者的激烈回应后, 警察军队化的忧虑, 便成为重要的公共政策议题。此一事件以具象化的方式赤裸地提醒着, 诸多美国警察部门已使用联邦计画来取得过剩的军事装备, 包括武器、配有装甲的运输工具, 以及防弹背心。我们探讨其中一个名为 1033 的最为重要的计画之历史与地理, 该计画以从事反图品战争为由, 提供警方军事装备。我们揭露在国家层级上, 警察和军队之间模糊化的法律界限已行之有年, 但此般境况却导致乡村层级中警察军队化的不均地景。我们同时探讨有关警察为何军队化的最为普遍的全球主张之一, 亦即特种武器和战术部队式的准军事团队的存在, 但却发现鲜少证据能支持此一主张。我们需要更关注地理面向的探问, 以理解警察军队化的轨迹、肇因和后果。**关键词: 1033, 法律执行, 军队化, 警备, SWAT** 。

Las preocupaciones por la militarización de la policía se han convertido en un importante asunto de política pública desde aquella agresiva respuesta de la policía a las protestas del 2014 en Ferguson, Missouri, donde los agentes de la policía utilizaron equipos de tipo militar para confrontar a los manifestantes. Tal evento fue una dura advertencia visual de que muchos departamentos de policía de los EE.UU. han aprovechado programas federales para adquirir excedentes de equipamiento militar, incluso vehículos blindados, armas y armaduras blindadas. Exploramos las geografías e historias de uno de los programas más importantes, el denominado 1033, que abastece a la policía con equipo militar bajo la lógica de contribuir más a la Guerra contra las Drogas. Mostramos que el artilugio legal de la policía y de los militares ha operado durante décadas a escala nacional, aunque esto ha resultado en un paisaje desigual de militarización de la policía a escala de condado. Investigamos también una de las razones globales más comunes que se esgrimen sobre porqué se ha militarizado la policía, cual es la existencia de grupos paramilitares por el estilo de Armas y Tácticas Especiales, hallando escasa justificación para aquel argumento. Se necesita más indagación geográfica para entender las trayectorias, causas y consecuencias de la militarización policial. **Palabras clave: 1033, cuerpos policiales, militarización, vigilancia policial, SWAT.**

In August 2014, the militarization of U.S. police departments was on public display as police officers who were dressed like soldiers used military-style equipment and armored vehicles to confront protestors in Ferguson, Missouri. Following the shooting death of a black teenager by a white Ferguson police officer, the Ferguson city and St. Louis County police employed military-style tactics to confront large protests, both peaceful and violent, that emerged in the area of the shooting. The police tactics emphasized the use of Special Weapons and Tactics (SWAT) teams in military-style uniforms and body armor to confront protestors and even involved the deployment of snipers atop armored vehicles. This militarized response by local police was thoroughly documented by local, national, and international media and drew criticism from numerous commenters and public officials (Shesgreen 2014).

Much of the public's interest in the events in Ferguson was grounded in the well-worn and historically familiar racial dimensions of the shooting, particularly the relations between a black public and a white police force. The police response was also a stark visual reminder, however, of the militarization of civilian law enforcement agencies (LEAs) in the United States, many of which have used federal programs to acquire surplus military equipment, including weapons, armored vehicles, and body armor. This article explores the geographies and histories of one the most important equipment acquisition programs, called

The Professional Geographer, 0(0) 2016, pages 1–11 © Copyright 2016 by American Association of Geographers
Initial submission, August 2015; revised submissions, December 2015 and May 2016; final acceptance, May 2016.
Published by Taylor & Francis Group, LLC.

1033, to better contextualize an important element of the phenomena of U.S. police militarization. Our goal is to provide a historicized and spatialized understanding of the 1033 program that situates events like the response to the Ferguson protests as localized expressions of a larger and more systematic process.

We begin by discussing how geographers have examined the topic of policing before introducing a theory of police and the state and the notion of police militarization. Next we describe the 1033 program, emphasizing its history and legal rationales to clarify the connections between the program and the war on drugs. We then explore the geographic extents of 1033 at the county level using data from the Department of Defense, finding that the overall usage of the program has increased dramatically in recent years, that there is a great deal of spatial variability in the utilization of the program by LEAs, and that the usage of the program is not just restricted to large counties with paramilitary SWAT-style policing units. Our concluding discussion emphasizes the implications of our findings for future research and why sustained geographic inquiry is essential to understanding the varied processes of police militarization.

## Geographies of Policing

Geographers have long noted the centrality of notions of place, territory, and space to policing (Yarwood 2007). For instance, many of the everyday activities of the police emphasize the need for officers to have a detailed and nuanced understanding of the places and people they are tasked with managing (Fyfe 1991; Yarwood and Paasche 2015), whereas formalized police patrol beats are spaces of law enforcement used to organize, partition, and manage policing efforts (Paasche, Yarwood, and Sidaway 2014), reflecting the use of territory to influence or control social interactions (Sack 1983). Further, many of the tactics that police use to manage affairs within their beats are inherently spatial, such as dispersing people from a particular location, creating checkpoints to limit movement, or relocating individuals through detention or arrest (Herbert 1996b, 1997; Crank 2015). In sum, place knowledge, territoriality, and the spatial management of people are important ways in which social order within places is made geographic.

Geographers have also explored the "thin blue line" police subculture that celebrates the role of police in preserving social order (Balko 2013). Police culture is often described as exhibiting a highly masculinist ethos that prizes the use of force while embracing a deep suspicion of the public (Fyfe 1991; Herbert 1998) and has been represented as a key way to understand the everyday actions of police (Crank 2015). Because places are an important mediator of social life, geographers have also drawn attention to the variability of police culture. For instance, Fyfe (1991) compared policing approaches at the national scale, concluding that police subculture is not monolithic and should be expected to vary geographically. Similarly, Herbert (1998) argued that elements of police culture vary institutionally, which serves as a geographic insight as policing in the United States is highly decentralized and localized (Klinger 2004).

As a contextual explanation of police behavior, Fyfe (1992) claimed that police culture alone might receive too much attention from researchers and that other contexts are also important influences on and mediators of policing. For example, the rise of neoliberal governance has shifted some aspects of policing toward a myriad set of private companies (Paasche, Yarwood, and Sidaway 2014) while also emphasizing the responsibility of individuals to police their own spaces through voluntary programs like neighborhood watch (England 2008). Neoliberalism has also been connected to the deployment of zero-tolerance policing policies in particular spaces within cities in support of businesses and commerce (Mountz and Curran 2009) or through police efforts to clear some urban neighborhoods of homeless people in support of gentrification (Smith 2002). An important challenge for geographers is to therefore connect how such larger scale contexts affect the everyday practices of policing within places.

Considering the legal limitations on police power provides an important example of why such larger contexts matter. For instance, police in the United States are legally constrained from entering private property without permission or probable cause, which affects the conduct of police during calls to private residences (Herbert 1996a). Laws that locate some spaces as beyond the reach of police power illustrate how the immediate contexts of policing are themselves partly constituted by larger scale processes. The national-scale legal structures that clearly delimit police power are also important elements of the everyday decisions and actions of the police and are present in their interactions with the policed. Such large-scale influences, whether de jure or de facto, should be seen as therefore vitally important contextual elements for understanding how policing works within particular places.

It is important to note that despite the preceding discussion, relatively little work on policing has been published by geographers. Perhaps apart from the notable exception of the collected work of Herbert, Fyfe's (1991) call for more engagement by geographers was largely ignored; Yarwood's (2007) similar call seems to have had the same limited impact to date. Although it is not clear why the topic continues to have such a small footprint within geography, we speculate that the difficulties of conducting data-driven research, qualitative or quantitative, with such a notoriously closed group might be part of the story. In any event, we agree with both Fyfe (1991) and Yarwood (2007) that the topic has great potential for geographers simply given the salience of power and space to policing.

## Police and the State

This rather small literature by geographers on police has tended to focus on the everyday activities of police

officers within specific institutional–geographic contexts, such as Herbert's (1996a, 1996b) studies of the Los Angeles Police Department. In some ways, this emphasis has reflected a larger trend in the study of police beyond geography, which emphasizes the institution of "the police" that is tasked with responding to crime and enforcing the law. Much of this literature takes the police for granted by focusing on the tasks, strategies, and actions of policing institutions without clearly articulating a broader sense of what police are. Other efforts to theorize police have focused on the power of police to order social life (e.g., Neocleous 2006, 2014), which has led to a consideration of policing as a form of state power.

Approaching police through the lens of the state was largely inspired by Foucault's notion of governmentality (Dubber and Valverde 2006). For example, Foucault (2007) traced the history of the idea of police in Europe and argued that it refers to the "means by which the state's forces can be increased while preserving the state in good order" (313). Following this argument, the police could be said to be part of a broader technology of governance and crucial to the everyday functioning of the state. Although this perspective suggests that the aspects of social life that might be policed are wide and varied, Neocleous (2006) anchored the idea of policing in class terms: Within modern states, "the police mandate was to fabricate an order of wage labor and administer the class of poverty thereafter" (21). Evidence for the relationship between the police and economic practices of the state can be found in examples as diverse as the tax collection responsibilities of sheriffs in Norman-era England (Williams 2004) and the repeated examples of the use of police forces as strikebusters in the United States during the nineteenth and twentieth centuries (Spitzer and Scull 1977; Walker 1977).

Although such a theory of police is largely compatible with the geographic perspectives on police activity described earlier, these theories are also partial as they tend to evoke and reinforce the classic domestic–foreign spatiality of the state. Police are then typically described in this literature as concerned with social order within "the interior of the state" (Foucault 2007, 327). However, the spatiality of police and the state is more complex than this simple binary for at least two interrelated reasons. First, the development of formal institutions of policing within individual states was, in some cases, grounded in extraterritorial politics. A prime example is found in the introduction of the first uniformed police force in London in the late 1820s (the so-called Peelers), which was itself was modeled on the experience of enforcing British colonial rule in Ireland (Williams 2004). As such, the introduction of a new means to provide domestic order within the space of the state was partly "informed by the experience of colonial rule" (Williams 2004, 35). That the experiences of colonial control could affect the practices of policing disrupts the simple territorial binary found in most policing theory and is evocative of Foucault's (1997) observation that dominating other societies had implications for the colonizer at home as "the West could practice something resembling . . . an internal colonialism, on itself" (103).

The second challenge to the binary spatiality of police and the state is that historically the scale of policing activity tends to be very localized, creating a highly differential set of motives, tasks, and contexts within which policing occurs (Dubber and Valverde 2006). This can be seen in the differences between "slave patrol" police forces in the U.S. South and the early modern urban police departments in many northern U.S. cities (Harring 1983). Slave patrols, first introduced into Southern colonies as early as the mid-1600s, were official efforts to catch runaway slaves, prevent slave gatherings, "and generally intimidate the Black population" (Williams 2004, 40). Although the details varied among the colonies with such patrols, the motives and logics of this form of policing centered on maintaining the status quo of slavery. In contrast, the uniformed urban police forces introduced in the 1840s and 1850s were focused not on the needs of the system of slavery but on those of the local political machines of the era. As Fogelson (1977) wrote, the goal of these police forces was rarely about keeping order in the streets; and violence between social groups was actually often tolerated as a means to "keep competing groups in their place" (19). Instead, police were largely concerned with "preserving order at the polls" to ensure that their political patrons won reelection (Fogelson 1977).

We generally accept the Foucault-inspired approach to police as part of the state as well as Neocleous's understanding of police as concerned with the maintenance of the economic status quo. We also assert that theorizing police and as part of the state necessarily involves a complex set of scales and geographies that includes the local, the national, and, perhaps at times, the international as well. Certain sites will also be important to the realization of police power at specific moments in time (country backroads, urban polling places, picket lines, the colony), but these sites will vary among a set of states as well as within any given state. In addition, a close connection of police to the needs of the state implies that other aspects of state power need to be considered as well.

## Police and the Military

State-centered theories of policing have led some to reflect on the connections between police and another potent form of state power, the military. Enloe (1980) remarked that together the police and the military represent the legal use of a state's coercive force, and Turk (1982) explicitly linked the two by arguing that police are a means of producing social order within the territory of a state without resorting to the use of direct military control. Although these perspectives are largely drawn from modern examples of policing,

Kraska and Kappeler (1997) described what they call the close connections between police and the military historically and politically in the United States. These connections are found from the earliest days of police forces in the United States in the adoption of uniforms and military-style ranks. Further, the use of a military analogy that framed crime and disorder as a "war" was among the chief strategies used by a police reform movement in the early twentieth century to break the hold of local politicians and the political machines over what was seen as a set of corrupt local police institutions. Fogelson (1977) described this strategy as tapping into a "widespread admiration for the navy and army" at the time by emphasizing the "integrity, efficiency, and dignity of the military" (57) and that this reform effort led to a more militarized police in the United States.

The use of the war analogy by the police in producing and maintaining social order has been repeated many times since (Simon 2007) and is ultimately grounded in an underlying philosophy or ideology of *militarism* in which the threat or use of force to resolve social or political issues is seen as normal, unproblematic, and efficient; *militarization* then refers to the myriad ways in which the ideology is put into practice within a society (Enloe 2004). Both ideas are of growing importance for geographers and have been recently linked to a diverse set of issues in the United States such as the production of citizenship (Bernazzoli and Flint 2010), urban design (Graham 2010), environmentalism (Lunstrum 2014), health care (Loyd 2009), and migration (Silvey 2006). Militarism and militarization is an important lens for such diverse issues because of the trend toward "securitizing" social problems by framing them as threats to be attacked and overcome (Bernazzoli and Flint 2009a). These ideas have obvious utility for policing as the repeated use of the war metaphor toward social problems like crime or drugs frames them as emergencies requiring urgent martial solutions (Kraska 2001).

Although militarization takes on many forms, Bernazzoli and Flint (2009b) noted that it works similarly to Gramsci's (1971) notion of cultural hegemony, which claims that the poorest members of society tended to adopt the values and norms of wealthy elites to explain why the working classes often act against their own economic self-interest. Bernazzoli and Flint argued that the processes of militarization work similar to cultural hegemony as the ideology of militarism is widely accepted even by those who might not benefit from such an understanding, especially when the military has an elevated status within a society. Despite the pervasiveness of the ideology of militarism, it is important to note that processes of militarization are always realized within places and therefore should be expected to be, as Woodward (2005) pointed out, "temporally and spatially contingent" (720). Accordingly, militarism could be understood as an important yet often overlooked element of place construction, and militarization should be expected to present an uneven spatial expression as the adoption of the ideology of militarism and the specific within-place practices inspired by it might vary widely.

The well-documented reliance on war metaphors (war on crime, war on drugs) by police and the historical reliance on force to produce social order led Kraska (2007) to argue that policing is a self-evidently militarized part of the state. As a consequence, research should be focused on the extent of its militarization rather than its existence. Along these lines, the rise of specialized paramilitary units in large urban police forces, such as the well-known SWAT teams in the United States, has been identified as an important contemporary indicator of the extent of police militarization (Kraska and Kappeler 1997; see also Herzog 2001). Although the historical origins of SWAT teams are typically described as a response to specific instances where police found themselves underequipped or "outgunned" (Balko 2013), these units often have direct connections to the military by hiring veterans with military training. SWAT teams have been critiqued as a direct threat to civil liberties and public safety due to the growth in their overall number and in their increasing use in everyday policing (American Civil Liberties Union 2014).

SWAT teams have comprised the focus of the limited research on police militarization to date (den Heyer 2014). For example, Meeks (2006) contended that the use of SWAT teams in urban policing strategies unevenly targets the urban poor and people of color in selective prosecution of a "war on crime," and Falcone, Wells, and Weisheit (2002) argued that rural or small-town departments without SWAT-style units are on the right side of the trend as the introduction of SWAT-style units in these settings undermines trust between the police and the public. Although these and other critiques of SWAT teams (see also Hill and Beger 2009) differ in many ways, they agree that their use is (or should be) a point of concern. A limitation of this emphasis on SWAT teams and their adoption of military-style equipment and tactics is that it is fixated on the obvious visible or material connections between policing and the military, such as those observed during the Ferguson protests.

Despite their importance to policing and to the public perception of the police, the presence or absence of these paramilitary units should not constitute the extent of police militarization as a police force can be militarized by other actions or practices even if it is without a SWAT unit. For example, the Latah County (Idaho) Sheriff, which serves a jurisdiction of roughly 38,000 people spread across 1,000 square miles in northern Idaho, has no SWAT team or specialized paramilitary unit but did acquire a military armored vehicle in 2014 (see Figure 1; Harber 2014). Even without the direct military connections that are often present with SWAT teams (Kraska 2007), military equipment and materials can still flow to police departments in the United States in a variety of settings. A more comprehensive understanding of the processes of police militarization requires more than just a focus on SWAT trends

**Figure 1** *Latah (Idaho) County's "Peacekeeper" armored vehicle was obtained by the Sheriff in 2014. In an interview with the local newspaper about the acquisition, a county commissioner was quoted as saying, "The roof is a good place for a machine gun" (Harber 2014). Photograph by Lanny McAden.*

because participation in federal programs like 1033 represents an important means by which police forces could become militarized without the obvious issues associated with SWAT teams.

## The 1033 Program and the War on Drugs

The implications of the so-called war on drugs have been well documented by a wide range of scholars. For instance, the criminalization of drug use has been linked to rising incarceration rates in the United States and offered an as explanation for the racialized nature of the penal system that disproportionately affects people of color (e.g., Lynch 2012). Others have explored the political origins of the war on drugs (e.g., Simon 2007; Frydl 2013), its links to the neoliberal dismantling of the welfare state (e.g., Beckett 1997; Corva 2008), and its impacts in societies beyond the United States (e.g., Rincón-Ruiz and Kallis 2013). The connections between the drug war and aggressive policing, such as the type associated with SWAT teams, have also been well documented (Beckett 1997; Simon 2007; American Civil Liberties Union 2014). The drug war's connections to other aspects of police militarization are less well known, however. The Department of Defense's (DoD) 1033 program, which provides surplus military equipment at no direct cost to LEAs, was directly born out of the war on drugs and is a crucial driver of the material militarization of police.

Created by federal legislation in 1996, 1033 specifies that military equipment may be transferred to LEAs to support antidrug efforts. The type of equipment available ranges from armored vehicles, personal protective equipment (helmets, vests, etc.), radios, firearms, and uniforms, to more mundane items like office furniture, computers, televisions, and air conditioners. The types and amounts of available equipment vary over time and LEAs can routinely browse 1033 inventories online. The DoD manages the 1033 program through the Law Enforcement Support Office (LESO). The LESO Web site claims that it has distributed surplus military equipment valued at $4.3 billion since 1996 (Defense Logistics Agency 2015).

1033 draws its name from the section of the National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Year 1997 that made it permanent in 1996 (Pub. L. No. 104–201 1996). The program has deep legislative roots, however, and is the direct product of the U.S. military's growing involvement in the drug war beginning in the 1980s. What would eventually become 1033 was first introduced in a 1988 defense funding bill that rewrote significant portions of federal law on the relationship between the military and local LEAs by specifying an active role for the military in antidrug efforts (Pub. L. No. 100–456 1988). The 1988 law itself was built on previous legislation passed in 1981 that allowed the military to provide temporary assistance in support law enforcement in drug interdiction, immigration control, or customs on a case-by-case basis (Pub. L. No. 97–86 1981; see also Hess 1990). Prior to the enactment of these two laws, the use of the military in matters of domestic law enforcement had been strictly prohibited by the Posse Comitatus Act of 1878.

The sum of these changes to the legal relationships between the military and police greatly increased the responsibilities of the DoD in prosecuting the drug war; the DoD was tasked with serving as the lead federal agency for "the detection and monitoring of aerial and maritime transit of illegal drugs into the United States" (Pub. L. 100–456 1988). As part of this newly legal mission, the DoD was also to make available to LEAs any equipment that was deemed necessary for them to carry out their drug interdiction efforts. A year later, Congress again expanded the military's role in the drug war with the National Defense Authorization Act for Fiscal Years 1990 and 1991 (Pub. L. No. 101–189 1989), which formally created the 1033 program. 1033 was specified to expire in 1992 but was renewed periodically in defense spending bills until a 1996 defense spending bill (Pub. L. No. 104–201 1996) that made it a permanent feature of the legal relationship between the U.S. military and civilian LEAs.

The main rationale for this program in the 1980s was to fight the drug war that had been part of federal policy since at least the late 1960s (Scott 2003; Frydl 2013).[1] The issue of substance abuse and its collective impact on U.S. society was initially framed as a national security threat by political elites during the Vietnam War, as it was seen as a particular problem in prosecuting the war in Vietnam (Savage and Gabriel 1976). For example, heroin use by U.S. soldiers fighting in the war was framed as "an epidemic" by President Richard Nixon in 1971 following a series of reports about the extent of heroin use in the U.S.

Army (Baker 1971). Although there were other political motives for creating a new role for the federal government in law enforcement, such as race and political dissent (Beckett 1997), the drug issue was the center of a major policy effort by the Nixon Administration to provide new resources to local law enforcement to "stem the tide of drug abuse which has swept America in the last decade" (Nixon 1971).

The prosecution of the war in Vietnam and the aims of U.S. foreign policy at the time shed light on why the federal policies established by Nixon eventually culminated in a direct connection between the military and LEAs through the 1033 program. The perception that heroin addiction was undermining the war effort in Vietnam meant that the issue of drug use and abuse had risen from a matter of domestic law enforcement within U.S. cities to a national emergency that required new action at home and abroad. In part, this meant a shift away from a treatment-based approach to drug crimes and toward a militarized approach; U.S. borders and territory had to be secured against the flow of heroin from abroad, which required military involvement. Although Nixon did not directly call for the program that ultimately became 1033, the seeds for such a move were planted decades ago (Beckett 1997; Simon 2007).

## Geographies of 1033

Although 1033 has been in existence in some form since the late 1980s, the program has operated largely outside of public awareness or scrutiny. The DoD made partial records available to the public in late 2014, however, as part of a series of media stories that highlighted the existence of the program (e.g., Rezvani et al. 2014). These data covered 1033 activities from 2006 through early 2014 and were aggregated to the county where the equipment was sent. These data also contained detailed descriptions of the equipment, the date that the equipment was transferred, and an estimated value of the equipment. Following Kraska's (2007) call to better understand the extents and trajectories of police militarization, we used these data to conduct an exploratory spatial analysis of the overall spacing and timing of acquisitions at the county scale from 2006 through the end of 2013.

During this eight-year period, more than 2,329,000 equipment transfers to LEAs were recorded (Table 1).[2] Equipment was distributed to 80 percent of all U.S. counties and the number of transfers per county varied widely. Within counties that received equipment, transfers ranged from a low of 1 to a high of more than 177,000. In addition, equipment transfers were highly concentrated in just a few counties: Forty-two counties were recorded as the destination of more than 10,000 transfers during the eight-year time period and the ten counties with the most transfers accounted for 40 percent of the total (see Table 2). Although LEAs are able to request and acquire equipment at no direct cost, the estimated value of each item is recorded, which provides an alternate measure of the program for analysis. The total value of all of the equipment transferred was over $1.5 billion (Table 1) with a lowest total value of $10 and a highest value of over $209 million. Similar to the transfers, just a handful of counties represented a significant portion of the total value: Twenty-five counties received equipment valued at over $100 million during the time period and the ten counties with the highest cumulative values represented over 27 percent of the total value (Table 2).

All of the equipment in the data was identified using the U.S. government's detailed Federal Supply Classification (FSC) system, which consists of seventy-eight groups and 645 subclasses (see Defense Logistics Agency [2003] for a complete classification list). Such detail was unnecessary for our analysis and we instead reclassified equipment into one of six broad categories (weapons, personal protective equipment, communication and surveillance, vehicles, armored vehicles, and miscellaneous) to simplify interpretation (see Table 3). Without regard to these categories, the annual value of transferred equipment increased from $34 million in 2006 to $530 million in 2013; the average annual increase in equipment value was 75 percent each year. The growth in the program, however, was largely due to increases in the transfers of vehicles (unarmored and armored) and of equipment that we assigned to the miscellaneous category (see Table 3 and Figure 2).[3] These trends likely reflect the types of equipment that became available following the process of demobilizing U.S. forces from Iraq that began in late 2007.

As previously noted, the geography of 1033 equipment transfers was highly variable, with some counties receiving over $200 million in equipment and many others receiving none at all. Mapping both the summed value of equipment received by county and the summed value per capita using county population estimates from the 2010 census highlights two notable spatial patterns (see Figure 3). First, a large cluster of counties with low-value per capita acquisitions is present across several Great Plains states, with more localized low-value clusters present in Pennsylvania and Texas. Second, small clusters of high per capita acquisitions were found in the Southeast (notably in Tennessee and Alabama), the Southwest (Arizona, Colorado, and New Mexico), and the northern Rockies (Montana). Both observations were confirmed with an exploratory test of local spatial autocorrelation and are suggestive that different processes might be at work both in different parts of the country and within states themselves (see Figure 4).

Given the emphasis on SWAT teams in the police militarization literature, we also examined whether the geography of equipment acquisitions was related to the presence of large urban departments that are more likely to have such specialized paramilitary units. Because there are no national data on the number or locations of SWAT teams in the United States, we used 2010 population estimates from the U.S. Census as a proxy measure given that small population counties are less likely to have such units (Falcone, Wells,

***Table 1*** *1033 equipment transfers and value by county, 2006–2013*[a]

| | Transfers[b] | Value |
|---|---|---|
| Total | 2,329,119 | $1,596,291,051 |
| Range | 0–177,695 | $0–$209,895,004 |
| Average | 741 | $507,888 |
| Median | 15 | $11,976 |

*Note*: 80 percent of all U.S. counties received equipment under the 1033 program from 2006 through 2013. The estimated total value of the transferred equipment was over $1.59 billion.
[a]Counties with no acquisitions or acquisitions of equipment valued at $0 are included in these figures.
[b]A transfer refers to the number of items requested.

and Weisheit 2002). Using the Kendall's $\tau$ nonparametric correlation test, we found that population had a moderate positive correlation both with the total number of equipment transfers (Kendall's $\tau = 0.396$, $p < 0.001$) and the equipment's overall value (Kendall's $\tau = 0.347$, $p < 0.001$). When considering the type of equipment based on our six categories, however, all categories had low positive correlations with population for both number of transfers and value with the exception of weapons, which had low negative correlations (Table 4). Population is obviously an imperfect proxy for the actual geography of SWAT teams, but these findings suggest that police militarization through the 1033 program is not simply a function of population distribution. By extension, police militarization is not likely to be a problem restricted to the geography of large urban police departments.

## Discussion

The 1033 program was, for decades, neither visible to the public nor a subject of study by scholars, even those interested in policing or militarization. Although Ferguson (St. Louis County, Missouri) was not a particularly notable destination for equipment procured through 1033, the events that occurred within Ferguson made 1033 and its usage by LEAs a highly visible and politicized issue. For example, the Obama Administration recently issued a report that recommended the restriction of certain types of military equipment to LEAs (White House 2015), and some state governments have advanced legislation to curb the usage of 1033.[4] These efforts have in common a focus on visibly provocative equipment, such as grenade launchers, while overlooking the more mundane aspects of 1033, such as equipment with no clear connection to policing. The administration's Law Enforcement Equipment Working Group recommended that the 1033 equipment lists "were expansive and included routine items such as office equipment, cameras, and plywood" that have no particular law enforcement purpose (White House 2015, 11). Extending this logic to our findings is illustrative, as the bulk of the equipment acquisitions by LEAs are clearly not of the type emphasized by these policy reports and legislation (see Figure 2). Such policies then only tinker around the edges of the issue and do little to address the broad and increasing usage of the program across the United States.

Another important finding of our study is that the usage of the program, either taken as a whole or with regard to certain types of equipment, is highly spatially variable. Figure 3A shows high levels of 1033 usage in Southern California and Arizona, but that pattern is largely a function of population measures (Figure 3B). Controlling for population does suggest pockets of higher usage in southern states like Alabama and mountain states like Montana and the reasons for these patterns are likely to be more localized. For example, the relationships between race and policing might have more explanatory power in the South, the Southwest, or in diverse urban settings than in more homogenous rural counties. Kraska's (2007) claim that police militarization is best understood as a continuum should be seen as necessarily having spatial contours;

***Table 2*** *The top ten counties for both number of equipment transfers and equipment value represented a large portion of the overall use of 1033 from 2006 through 2013*

| Transfers | | | Value | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1. | El Paso, TX | 177,695 | 1. | Brevard, FL | $209,895,004 |
| 2. | Los Angeles, CA | 164,365 | 2. | Jefferson, AL | $34,015,544 |
| 3. | Ventura, CA | 145,326 | 3. | Los Angeles, CA | $27,545,531 |
| 4. | Hidalgo, TX | 102,217 | 4. | Ventura, CA | $26,309,863 |
| 5. | Jefferson, AL | 62,973 | 5. | District of Columbia | $23,276,478 |
| 6. | Maricopa, AZ | 62,428 | 6. | Maricopa, AZ | $20,175,209 |
| 7. | Sacramento, CA | 56,152 | 7. | Sacramento, CA | $18,747,220 |
| 8. | Fulton, GA | 49,646 | 8. | Calhoun, AL | $18,627,976 |
| 9. | Oakland, MI | 42,648 | 9. | Arlington, VA | $17,533,916 |
| 10. | Kern, CA | 40,375 | 10. | Richland, SC | $15,249,910 |

*Note*: Transfers to El Paso County (Texas) accounted for over 7.5 percent of the total transfers; Brevard County (Florida) alone was the destination for equipment valued at nearly $210 million or 13.4 percent of the total value distributed throughout the United States.

***Table 3*** *Equipment value by category*

| Equipment type | Value, 2006–2013 ($) | % change, 2006–2013 |
|---|---|---|
| Armored vehicles | 13,152,136 | 328 |
| Personal protective equipment | 19,726,950 | 15,924 |
| Weapons | 82,120,120 | 32 |
| Communication and surveillance | 187,358,240 | 2,556 |
| Miscellaneous | 388,847,295 | 1,718[a] |
| Vehicles | 905,086,310 | 1,440 |
| Total: All equipment | 1,596,291,051 | 1,414 |

*Note*: The value of equipment acquired by law enforcement agencies has increased across all categories since 2006. Nonarmored vehicles comprise 56 percent of the total equipment value over the eight years from 2006 to 2013. Weapons and armored vehicles had the slowest increases despite being the type of equipment emphasized by new policy and legislative initiatives that aim to curb the usage of 1033.
[a]Percentage increase of the miscellaneous category calculated from 2009; no equipment was in this category from 2006 through 2008.

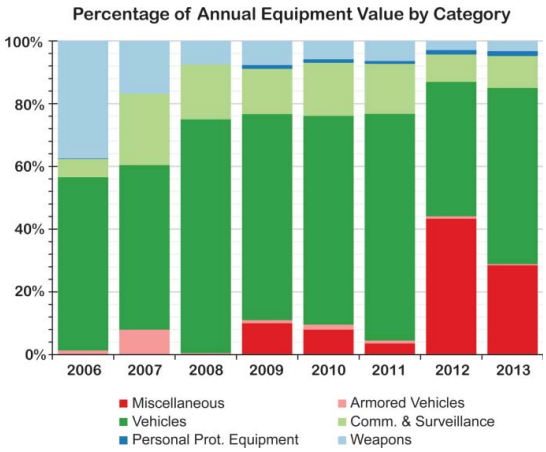


**Figure 2** *Tracking the percentage of equipment value by category from 2006 through 2013 shows that nonarmored vehicles comprise the bulk of the program, accounting for more than 50 percent of the total annual value for all years save one (2012, 42.8 percent). The value of weapons acquisitions has declined over time and recent growth in the overall program is attributable to the increase in miscellaneous equipment since 2009. (Color figure available online.)*

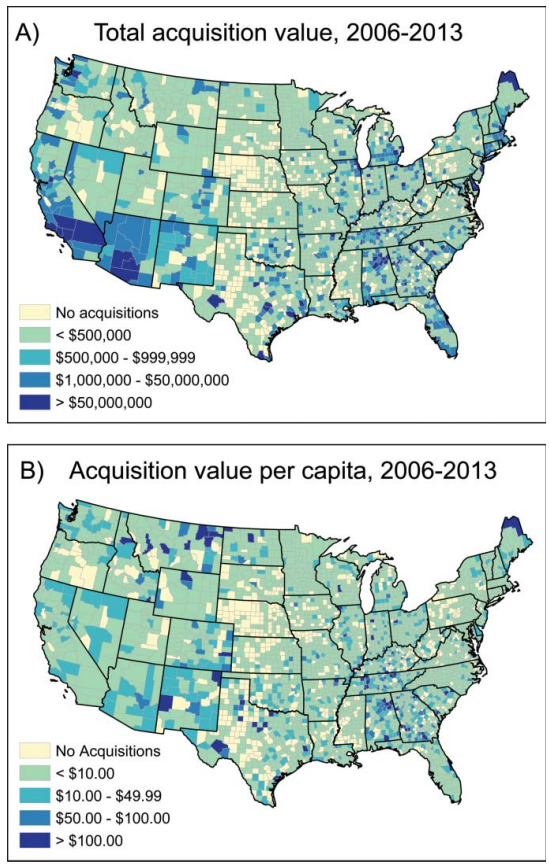


**Figure 3** *Equipment values were consistently high in (A) urban areas, but (B) rural counties are seen to be important equipment destinations when controlling for population. (Color figure available online.)*

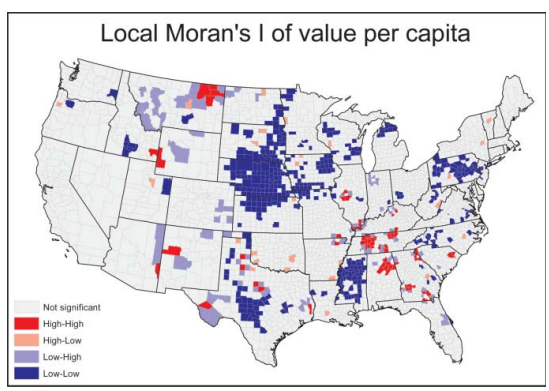


**Figure 4** *A local cluster analysis using a $k = 6$-nearest neighbor spatial weights matrix identified statistically significant clusters ($p < 0.05$) of high (red) and low (blue) value per capita acquisitions. Although many clusters occurred within a single state and might reflect state-level policy on 1033 acquisitions, the large low-value cluster in the center of the United States crossed state boundaries and might reflect a larger scale shared context that affected LEA decision making. (Color figure available online.)*

our findings are the first indication of the location of some of the possible contours when it comes to issues of racial diversity.

The importance of local and regional contexts for 1033 usage is also reinforced with our findings of statistically significant clusters of high and low acquisitions at the county scale. For instance, the groups of counties in Tennessee with similarly high 1033 equipment acquisitions (the red counties in Figure 4) are largely rural counties rather than those that encompass the major population centers in the state. It could be that there are shared contexts in those areas of the state that have led LEAs to make similar use of the program, but it is clear that these contexts are not geographically uniform. Somewhat differently, the group of high-usage counties in Alabama includes the Birmingham metro area and might reflect a shared perspective on the program among a group of interacting LEAs due to adjacent jurisdictions. In short, some of the clusters of high-usage counties might be the result of contexts that extend beyond the legal and spatial jurisdiction of a single LEA, but these are likely different within and between states. That is not to suggest that state-level policies on 1033 usage cannot be explanatory factors as well. For example, the large clusters of counties with similarly low 1033 usage (the blue counties in Figure 4) in Mississippi and Nebraska might indicate a strong oversight role being played by the state's 1033 coordinator, a state-level administrative position required by the DoD.

Apart from the narrow focus on SWAT teams, however, Kraska and others provide little guidance as to why such variations are likely to exist and, crucially for

***Table 4*** *Equipment acquisitions correlated with population*

| | Kendall's $\tau$ (rank-order)[a] | |
|---|---|---|
| | **Transfers** | **Value** |
| All equipment | 0.397 | 0.347 |
| Weapons | −0.207 | −0.068 |
| Armor | 0.208 | 0.238 |
| Communications | 0.157 | 0.176 |
| Vehicles | 0.038 | 0.084 |
| Armored vehicles | 0.168 | 0.166 |
| Miscellaneous | 0.136 | 0.150 |

*Note*: Population counts from the 2010 U.S. Census are moderately positively correlated with overall equipment transfers and value at the county scale using Kendall's $\tau$ rank-order correlation test. Weapons were negatively correlated with population increases and armored vehicles were only slightly positively correlated. Special Weapons and Tactics teams, often a feature of large urban law enforcement agencies, might not be as important to the geography of 1033 acquisitions as suggested by the literature.
[a]All tests were significant at $p < 0.01$.

geographers, where such highs and lows might be expected to occur. The variable regional histories of policing in the United States might be a helpful, although partial, lens on this issue (e.g., Williams 2004). A great deal of work remains for those interested in the processes that produce such variable outcomes, and the development of spatial data on the topic that can be used to test theory-driven hypotheses is an important next step. This will necessarily involve additional quantitative research using county-scale or smaller scale aggregated data to identify possible correlates to police militarization that might involve questions of racial or ethnic diversity, urban–rural differentiation, proximity to international boundaries and the perceived need to manage migrant flows, policing of drug transportation corridors within the United States, or issues pertaining to the geography of incarceration.

In parallel with the type of research already described, place-specific research is also clearly needed to better illuminate the ties between LEA decision making about 1033 and the type of justifications used to advance or counter the program within particular places. In other words, given the new transparency of 1033 and the ongoing national scrutiny of police conduct, how are the issues connected to 1033 understood locally? A survey of the discourses surrounding 1033 in particular settings might be a particularly helpful first step. For example, the Spokane (Washington) County Sheriff recently defended his agency's acquisition of fifty-seven M16 rifles through 1033 as necessary because law enforcement officials are "on the ISIS hit list" (Henterly 2015, 17), and the Latah (Idaho) County Sheriff emphasized the need for an armored vehicle to respond to mass shooting events, one of which occurred in the county in 2007 (Harber 2014). These justifications rely on different scales (one with the global war on terror, the other with local events) but, tellingly, neither focuses on the drug war or how it has unfolded within those particular jurisdictions. Following Fyfe (1991) and others, scholarship of this sort will necessarily involve qualitative inquiry about the unique local-scale impacts on LEA actions and justifications but should also consider how the larger scale processes of militarization, particularly those having to do with issues of foreign policy and national security, are mediated within particular places (Bernazzoli and Flint 2009b).

Finally, more historical geographic investigation is needed of the myriad legal structures and programs beyond 1033 that connect LEAs and the military. For instance, in addition to 1033, LEAs can acquire military-style equipment through programs run by the departments of Justice and Homeland Security (Rahall 2015). How have the laws connected to these sorts of programs changed over time and what are the associated spatial worldviews that underpin them? The justification of the Spokane Sheriff is perhaps an obvious example in a possible shift away from antidrug and toward antiterrorism rationales in maintaining the flow of military equipment to police, but there might be other relevant trends. Scholarship of this sort could also be fruitful in clarifying the role of race in police militarization. For instance, linkages between the geographies of the civil rights movement and the politics of gun control within particular places might also partially explain the varied landscape of police militarization in the United States.

We conclude by noting that our research is but a part of a larger set of questions regarding policing and the geography of socially constructed spaces of control that have emerged since the events of Ferguson in 2014. Although many of these questions have focused on the racial dynamics that have been implicated by the use of force by police officers in specific cases, the kind of material militarization represented by 1033 is another window on the issue that can perhaps clarify a larger and crucial context that such individual cases are embedded within. Our research shows that the legal blurring of the police and the military that has enabled the spread of military equipment to LEAs has been ongoing for decades at the national scale, but this has resulted in an uneven landscape of police militarization at the county scale. Highlighting the presence of such spatial variability and ruling out simple global explanations for it, such as SWAT teams, opens a new range of questions including, but not limited to, those described earlier. Geographers then should be expected to play an important role in moving toward a more nuanced understanding of the trajectories, causes, and consequences of police militarization. ■

## Acknowledgments

We are indebted to the two anonymous reviewers and the editor for their suggested improvements to this article; any remaining deficiencies are our responsibility alone. We also wish to thank Theresa Stinchfield for preparing some of the data used in our analysis.

## Notes

[1] Antiterrorism activity by LEAs was included as a justification for equipment transfers in the 1996 legislation but was not present in the bills in the 1980s. Despite the inclusion of terrorism, the details of the 1996 bill are focused on drug interdiction.

[2] This includes transfers to LEAs within the fifty states, the District of Columbia, Guam, Puerto Rico, and the U.S. Virgin Islands. Each record in the data represents the transfer of either a single item or a group of identical items.

[3] The miscellaneous category includes anything that did not easily fit with the other categories; examples of the items in this category include office furniture, computers, exercise equipment, kitchen supplies, and air conditioners.

[4] In March 2015, New Jersey passed a law requiring more local oversight of 1033 requests made by LEAs (Rimbach 2015); the following month, Montana enacted a law prohibiting the acquisition of weaponized drone aircraft and grenade launchers by LEAs (Carter 2015).

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